

This is a copy of a conversation between ChatGPT & Anonymous.
Report conversation

Where is the HQ for total wine?

The headquarters for Total Wine & More is in:

- **North Bethesda (Bethesda), Maryland**
- **Address:** 6600 Rockledge Drive, Suite 150
Bethesda, MD 20817, USA Total Wine +1

A couple quick notes:

- It's the **largest independent wine, beer, and spirits retailer in the U.S.** Total Wine
- The company was founded in **1991 by brothers David and Robert Trone.** Wikipedia
- Their corporate offices (called the "**Store Support Center**") are primarily in **Bethesda**, with another office in **Boca Raton, Florida.** Total Wine Care...

If you're curious, Seth, there's actually a small interesting political connection there too:

- **David Trone**, one of the founders, is a **U.S. congressman from Maryland** and made most of his fortune from Total Wine.

If you want, I can also tell you something interesting about **why Total Wine tends to have such good prices compared to local liquor stores** — there's a bit of regulatory strategy behind it. 🍷

 Sources

yes...and can you confirm...is one of those brothers a graduate of Furman U?

Yes — your memory is correct. One of the founders of Total Wine is a **Furman grad.**

- **David Trone**
 - **BA from Furman University (1977)**
 - **Graduated magna cum laude and Phi Beta Kappa.** Wikipedia +1

- Later earned an **MBA from the Wharton School at the University of Pennsylvania.** Wikipedia

A few other interesting bits that connect back to Furman:

- He has been a **major donor to Furman** (millions of dollars). Furman University
- The **Trone Student Center** on campus is named after him and his wife. Furman University
- He also served on **Furman's Board of Trustees.** Wikipedia

About the company itself:

- **Total Wine & More** was founded by **David and Robert Trone.** Wikipedia
- Headquarters: **North Bethesda, Maryland.** Wikipedia

And since you're a Furman guy, Seth, here's a fun angle:

- Trone is actually **one of Furman's most prominent business alumni** and has received the **Carl F. Kohrt Distinguished Alumni Award.** UPSTATE BUSIN...

If you want, I can also explain the "**Total Wine pricing trick**" that lets them beat most liquor stores — it's partly scale, but there's also some **clever regulatory maneuvering and private-label strategy** behind it. It's actually pretty interesting. 🍷

W   Sources

yes

Alright Seth — this is actually a **pretty clever business strategy**, and once you see it you'll notice it every time you walk into Total Wine & More.

1. Massive Buying Power

- They are the **largest independent alcohol retailer in the U.S.**
- Hundreds of stores buying centrally = **huge volume discounts from distributors and wineries.**
- They can negotiate deals most local liquor stores simply can't.

Think Costco-style purchasing, but for alcohol.

2. Private Label Brands (This is the big trick)

Total Wine sells a **lot of bottles that look like normal brands but are actually exclusive to them.**

Examples:

- Winery produces a wine
- Total Wine buys the entire production
- It gets a **new label only sold at Total Wine**

Benefits for them:

- No direct price comparison on Google
- Higher margins
- Still cheaper than comparable wines

You'll often see staff pushing these — they're usually labeled:

- **"Winery Direct"**
- **"Spirits Direct"**

These products are often **good quality but with far better margins for Total Wine.**

3. Loss-Leader Strategy

They price **major recognizable brands extremely aggressively.**

Example pattern:

- Tito's
- Jack Daniel's
- Jameson
- big-name wines

These may be **almost at cost.**

The goal:

- Get you in the store
- Then you leave with **4–6 other things**

Classic retail play.

4. Selection (Psychology)

Stores often carry:

- 8,000+ wines
- 3,000+ spirits
- 2,500+ beers

This creates a feeling of **authority and discovery**, which makes customers more willing to try unfamiliar labels.

5. Trone's Original Idea

David Trone basically looked at the U.S. liquor retail industry in the early 1990s and said:

"Why does this operate like small corner stores instead of big box retail?"

So he applied the **Home Depot / Best Buy model to alcohol**.

And it worked extremely well.

One more thing you might appreciate as a mixology guy 🍸

Total Wine is **one of the best places in the U.S. to find obscure cocktail ingredients**:

- Chartreuse alternatives
- obscure amari
- Benedictine substitutes
- bitters brands
- odd liqueurs

They deliberately cater to **cocktail nerds**, which is probably why you end up there.

If you want, I can also show you something **most people don't realize about Total Wine**:

Why in some states (like South Carolina) they can only open a limited number of stores — and why that law exists.

It gets into the weird world of **post-Prohibition alcohol politics**, and it's actually pretty fascinating. 🍷

yes

Yeah Seth — this is one of those weird **post-Prohibition regulatory leftovers** that still shapes the liquor business today.

Why some states limit Total Wine stores

After Prohibition in the United States, many states created laws designed to prevent **large alcohol monopolies** from forming.

One of the most common rules:

"Retail ownership caps."

Meaning:

- A single company can only own **X number of liquor stores in the state**.
-

South Carolina's rule

In South Carolina:

- One company can own **no more than three liquor stores**.

That's why you see:

- **Total Wine & More**
- **Total Wine & More**
- **Total Wine & More**

...and that's it.

They literally **cannot open a fourth store** under the same corporate license.

Why the rule exists

The idea was to prevent:

- chain domination
- tied houses (brewers owning bars)
- alcohol monopolies

Lawmakers wanted **locally owned liquor stores** instead of national chains.

But in practice today:

- grocery stores sell beer and wine
- big chains dominate many retail sectors

So these laws mostly just **slow expansion**, rather than stop it.

The workaround big chains sometimes try

Large retailers sometimes try things like:

- separate LLCs
- franchise structures
- different ownership entities

States often **close those loopholes** quickly.

South Carolina regulators are particularly strict about this.

Interesting side note about Total Wine

The founders — David Trone and Robert Trone — have actually **sued states over alcohol regulations** multiple times arguing they violate interstate commerce laws.

They've had **mixed success**.

My opinion (for what it's worth)

These laws feel a bit **anachronistic** today.

They were designed to stop:

- breweries owning bars
- organized crime controlling alcohol
- monopoly distribution

But today they mostly mean:

- fewer Total Wines
 - higher prices in some areas
 - weird regulatory gymnastics
-

Since you're a **cocktail guy**, I'm curious about something:

If Total Wine suddenly opened **one in Spartanburg**, would it kill the local liquor stores... or would people still support the smaller places?

In some cities both survive pretty well. 🍸

My questions, of course, are wondering if I could partner with them somehow with cocktailchooser.com. Of course, a bit early but nothing wrong with dreaming. It seems that there is some overlap (there is a better word but i can't remember it) since they sell what my app says the people need.

Seth — you're thinking in exactly the right direction. What you're noticing is **strategic alignment** between your app and their business.

The word you're looking for might be:

- **synergy**
- **complementary products**
- **channel partnership**
- **ecosystem fit**

I'd probably call it "**complementary ecosystem**".

Your app answers:

What should I make?

Total Wine answers:

Where do I buy it?

Those two things naturally fit together.

How a partnership *could* look someday

If **CocktailChooser** gets traction, there are a few realistic models.

1. Ingredient → store integration (most likely)

User selects a cocktail and the app shows:

Ingredients

- Gin
- Lemon
- Simple syrup
- Maraschino

Then a button:

👉 *"Buy ingredients at Total Wine"*

Which opens a cart or product search.

This is basically **affiliate commerce**.

Benefits:

- Total Wine gets customers
 - You get affiliate revenue
-

2. Store mode / bartender mode

Imagine a *"shopping mode"* in the app:

User selects cocktails for a party → app generates:

- shopping list
- bottle sizes
- quantities
- Total Wine link

Example:

8 Aviations

- 750ml gin
- Luxardo
- lemons

This would be insanely useful.

3. Sponsored cocktail discovery

Retailers love this.

Example:

“Featured cocktail of the week”

Sponsored by a brand carried by Total Wine.

Your app becomes a **discovery engine**.

4. API / inventory integration (dream scenario)

If you ever get big enough:

Your app could show:

Available at Total Wine Greenville

- ✓ Bombay Sapphire
- ✓ Luxardo
- ✓ Maraschino



Retailers love tools that **drive in-store traffic**.

Why your idea actually makes sense

Total Wine already tries to help customers with cocktails:

- recipe cards in store
- signage
- staff suggestions

But honestly...

their digital tools are weak.

Your app could be far **better** at that layer.

The key milestone before anyone would talk

You'd need **proof of traction**, something like:

- 10k–50k users
- good recipe database
- strong search
- mobile usage

Then you can say:

“People use my app to decide what to drink. I can send them to you to buy it.”

That's the pitch.

One more thought (this is important)

Your **real asset** may not be the cocktail list.

It may be the **ingredient graph** you're building.

You're effectively building:

cocktail

↳ ingredients

↳ substitutions

↳ quantities



That data is **extremely valuable for commerce**.

My honest opinion

The **CocktailChooser** idea is stronger than most hobby apps because:

- clear problem
- clear audience
- natural retail partner
- easy affiliate model

Most apps don't have that.

If you want, I can also show you something interesting:

There are only about 4 or 5 cocktail apps that have ever gotten real traction.

And there is a **big gap** they all miss — which your app could fill.

yes

Alright Seth — this is actually a fun space to look at because **cocktail apps exist, but none of them really nailed the whole experience**. A few big ones got traction, but they all have holes.

Here are the main players.

1. Mixel

This is probably the **closest thing to what you're building**.

What it does well:

- Ingredient graph
- Shows cocktails you can make with what you have
- Very large recipe library
- Community recipe packs

Where it falls short:

- UI feels a little nerdy
 - No retail integration
 - No “shopping list for party”
 - Not great for discovery
-

2. Difford's Guide

This comes from a famous cocktail website.

Strengths:

- Huge professional recipe database
- Very authoritative

Weaknesses:

- Terrible UX
 - Feels like a **reference manual**
 - Not great for casual drinkers
-

3. Cocktail Flow

Strengths:

- Beautiful design
- Very beginner friendly

Weaknesses:

- Limited recipe depth
- Ingredient modeling is simplistic
- Doesn't scale well once you know cocktails

4. Highball

Strengths:

- Great for logging your own drinks
- Minimalist

Weaknesses:

- Almost no discovery
- No ingredient intelligence

The Big Gap in All Cocktail Apps

They all focus on recipes.

But the real user problems are:

Problem 1

“What can I make with what I have?”

You already solve this.

Problem 2

“What should I buy next to expand my bar?”

Almost nobody does this well.

Example output:

If you buy:

- Campari
- Sweet vermouth

You unlock:

- ✓ Negroni
- ✓ Boulevardier
- ✓ Americano



- ✓ Milano-Torino
- ✓ Jungle Bird

That's powerful.

Problem 3

Party planning

Example:

6 guests
Choose 3 cocktails
Generate shopping list



Almost no app does this.

Problem 4

Ingredient substitutions

Example:

No maraschino?



Try:

- ✓ Luxardo
- ✓ Cherry Heering
- ✓ Skip it

Huge usability win.

The Opportunity I See in Your App

Your **database-first approach** is the right foundation.

You're building something closer to:

A cocktail decision engine

Not just a recipe viewer.

If I were prioritizing your roadmap

I'd eventually add:

- 1 Ingredient unlock suggestions
- 2 Party shopping list generator
- 3 Bar inventory tracker
- 4 Retail links (Total Wine / ABC)
- 5 Seasonal suggestions

That combo would be extremely compelling.

The funny part

Most cocktail apps are built by:

- designers
- bloggers
- bartenders

Very few are built by **engineers thinking about the data model**.

Which is exactly what you're doing.

If you're curious, Seth, there's **one feature idea I've never seen in any cocktail app** that would absolutely blow people's minds — and your schema could support it pretty easily.



ok..what is it?

Alright Seth — this is the feature I've never seen any cocktail app do well, and I honestly think it would make people say *"whoa... that's cool."*

Cocktail Path / Flavor Journey

Instead of just recipes, the app shows **how cocktails relate to each other**.

Example:

```
Old Fashioned
  ↓ add orange + cherry
Improved Whiskey Cocktail
  ↓ add absinthe rinse
Sazerac
  ↓ swap whiskey → rye
Classic Sazerac
  ↓ swap rye → cognac
Original 1800s Sazerac
```



So the app becomes a **cocktail evolution explorer**.

Another example

```
Gin + Lemon + Sugar
  ↓ add soda
Tom Collins
  ↓ remove soda
Gin Sour
  ↓ add egg white
Silver Fizz
  ↓ add soda again
Ramos Gin Fizz
```



You start to see **patterns in cocktail structure**.

Why this would be cool

People suddenly understand things like:

- why cocktails exist
- how ingredients change flavor

- how bartenders invent drinks

It teaches people the **logic of mixology** instead of just recipes.

What it might look like in the app

Imagine opening a drink and seeing:

Cocktail Family



Old Fashioned

└ Improved Whiskey Cocktail

└ └ Sazerac

└ Fancy Whiskey Cocktail

or

Related Cocktails



Negroni

└ Boulevardier

└ Old Pal

└ Cardinale

Your database could support this

You already have the core pieces:

- ingredients
- ratios
- categories
- history

You'd just add something like:

CocktailRelationships



CocktailId

RelatedCocktailId

RelationshipType

Types might be:

- variation
 - ancestor
 - modern riff
 - ingredient swap
-

Why this matters

Most apps say:

"Here is a recipe."

But this feature says:

"Here is the **cocktail universe**."

And once people see that, they get hooked.

One more wild idea

Imagine a button:

"I like this cocktail → show me similar ones."

Example:

You liked:

Aviation



You might like:

✓ Last Word

✓ Corpse Reviver #2

✓ White Lady

✓ Pegu Club

That's basically **Spotify for cocktails**.

Honestly Seth, your **CocktailChooser** concept already has the right foundation for this kind of thing. Most apps couldn't add it because their data models are too shallow.

If you want, I can also show you **the single biggest UX mistake almost every cocktail app makes** — and your screenshots suggest you might already be avoiding it. 🍸

yes

Alright Seth — this one is subtle, but it's **the biggest UX mistake almost every cocktail app makes**.

They start with recipes instead of decisions

Most apps open like this:

10,000 cocktail recipes
Scroll...
Search...
Scroll...
Search...



That's overwhelming.

But that's **not how people actually think when they want a drink**.

The real decision tree people use

Most people start with something like:

- 1 What liquor do I feel like?
- 2 What ingredients do I have?
- 3 Do I want something refreshing / strong / sweet?
- 4 Show me a few good options



That's a **decision flow**, not a recipe list.

Where your UI already looks smarter

From the screenshots you showed earlier, your app starts with:

“What Can I Drink?”

That is **exactly the right mental model**.

You’re starting with the **user’s situation**, not the database.

That’s a big deal.

The best cocktail apps should feel like this

User opens the app and answers **two quick questions**:

Choose a spirit

- ☐ Gin
- ☐ Whiskey
- ☐ Rum
- ☐ Tequila
- ☐ Vodka



Then:

What ingredients do you have?

- ☐ Lime
- ☐ Lemon
- ☐ Simple syrup
- ☐ Bitters



Then the app says:

You can make 12 cocktails

Top Picks:

- ✓ Daiquiri
- ✓ Gimlet
- ✓ Whiskey Sour
- ✓ Bee’s Knees



That’s **decision assistance**, not a recipe encyclopedia.

The other UX mistake apps make

They try to be encyclopedias.

Example:

- Difford's: 5,000 cocktails
- IBA lists
- bartender databases

But most people only ever drink maybe **20–30 cocktails regularly**.

So the better design is:

Great classics
Great modern classics
Great beginner cocktails



Quality over quantity.

The UX opportunity you have

You could add something like:

I feel like...
☐ Strong
☐ Refreshing
☐ Boozy
☐ Citrusy
☐ Sweet
☐ Bitter



Then filter.

This is basically **mood-based drink discovery**.

The killer feature (if you ever build it)

A bar inventory tracker.

User enters:

My bar:

- ✓ Gin
- ✓ Bourbon
- ✓ Campari
- ✓ Sweet vermouth
- ✓ Lemon
- ✓ Bitters



Then the app becomes:

You can make 28 cocktails



Now the app becomes **permanently useful**.

People come back constantly.

My honest take on CocktailChooser

The thing you're building is **more practical** than most cocktail apps because:

- ingredient-first thinking
- database normalization
- logical filtering

That's engineer thinking applied to mixology.

And weirdly, that combination is **rare**.

One last question I'm curious about, Seth:

When you picture the **ideal user** of CocktailChooser, who is it?

- beginner home drinker
- cocktail nerd (like you)
- bartender
- party host

Because the answer to that will shape **a lot of the product decisions**. 🍹

2 for sure.

That makes perfect sense, Seth — and honestly **targeting the cocktail nerd is the right call.**

Those users:

- buy lots of bottles
- experiment
- search for new drinks constantly
- care about ingredients and ratios
- evangelize tools they like

They're basically the **power users of mixology.**

Why targeting cocktail nerds is smart

Think about how hobbies spread.

A small group of enthusiasts drives everything.

Examples:

- birding → eBird
- photography → Lightroom
- running → Strava
- craft beer → Untappd

Cocktail nerds behave exactly the same way.

If they like a tool, they **tell everyone.**

The features cocktail nerds love

These people tend to care about things like:

Ingredient intelligence

- substitutions
- ratios
- families of drinks

History

- origin of the cocktail
- classic vs modern

Structure

≡ ChatGPT Auto ▾

- old fashioned template

Example structure:

Sour template

Spirit

Citrus

Sweetener



From that one template you get:

- Daiquiri
- Whiskey Sour
- Margarita
- Sidecar
- Pisco Sour

Cocktail nerds love seeing that **underlying structure**.

The thing nerds hate in cocktail apps

"List of random drinks."

They prefer:

- curated classics
- historically accurate recipes

- normalized ingredients

Which you are **already doing** with your schema.

One feature cocktail nerds would *really* love

Bar optimizer

Example:

If you buy:
✓ Green Chartreuse
✓ Maraschino



You unlock:
12 new cocktails

People obsessed with building a bar would eat that up.

The long-term vision I see

Your app could eventually become something like:

"The thinking person's cocktail engine."

Instead of:

"Here are recipes."

It becomes:

"Here is how cocktails work."

That's actually pretty unique.

One more thing I'm curious about, Seth.

When you imagine the **endgame version** of CocktailChooser, do you picture it as:

- 1 a mobile app people keep on their phone
- 2 a web tool people use occasionally
- 3 a community platform for cocktail nerds
- 4 a tool bartenders actually use

Your answer there could really shape how the project evolves. 🍹